

Gender Differences in Heterosexual Marital Sexting: Intimacy, Consent and Vulnerability

Introduction

As our daily communication has become largely digitalised, intimate practice within married couples is no longer confined to physical connection but extended to digital spaces. Intimacy is the process through which one person expresses love to someone, as well as “being close to” that person (Jamieson, 1998, p.1-2). Digital intimacy is to bring this emotional connection to online spaces to convey affection and closeness (Attwood, Hakim and Winch, 2017). One such practice between spouses is through sexting, which includes sending explicit messages to each other, as well as producing and exchanging pictures or videos via messaging applications and social media platforms (Tiidenberg and van der Nagel, 2020). Current research on sexting focuses mainly on teenagers and young adults, where it is often seen as a behaviour that is risky and should be educated or prevented (Döring, 2014). However, McDaniel and Drouin (2015) found that, although with different forms and less frequency, married adults also engage in sexting. Although the questions around sexting within marriage cannot be fully answered by youth-centred sexting narratives and non-marital relationships, the literature still provides significant insights regarding the benefits of sexting in intimate relationships, the absence of consent and its potential risks.

When situated within marriage, sexting complicates traditional understandings of intimacy and consent, as well as exposing the power structure embedded in gender, culture, and technology. Therefore, these aspects will be discovered through the lens of intersectionality, which refers to how multiple social positions, such as gender, race, religion, marital status, and other social categories, interact to shape lived experiences and power relations (Collins and Bilge, 2020). By drawing on this approach, this essay demonstrates how sexting in heterosexual marriage reproduces the hierarchies and gendered divisions of labour that are often normalised within marriage due to social and cultural norms, showing how digital intimacy is continuously shaped by unequal power relationships within marriage.

This essay proceeds in four parts. It first explores how intimacy operates in marriages, how it is shaped by gendered roles, and how these factors affect marital sexting. Next, it examines how consent in sexting is both negotiated and often misunderstood between partners due to the marital institution and the myth of permanent spousal consent. It then turns to how vulnerability in marital sexting is shaped by social and cultural structures, and finally, reflects on the wider social and political concerns that these dynamics bring to light, with a critical focus on gendered shame as a social disciplinary tool and the inadequacy of legal protection for digital marital harm.

Intimacy and “Emotion Work” in Marital Sexting

Although “sexting” is a portmanteau term combining “sex” and “texting”, its purpose is more than just sex, but to reflect, produce, and enhance intimacy (Amundsen, 2022). For example, during sexting, the emojis couples send, the facial expressions they make in videos can show their emotions and affection, transferring physical intimacy into a digital form. As sexting in relationships often requires both partners to engage in a reciprocal emotional exchange (Drouin, Coupe and Temple, 2017), with one partner initiating and the other responding, it suggests that intimacy is a shared interaction expressing emotional connection from both sides, rather than an individual expression. If one partner repeatedly initiates sexting while the other remains silent or uninterested, this can reflect a lower level of intimacy instead of strong affection. This illustrates how sexting is closely tied to the feedback received from a partner. Within marriage, this feedback is particularly essential as marital intimacy is often organised around expectations of ongoing and mutual responsiveness, rather than being treated as optional (Beck and Clark, 2010). Therefore, engaging in sexting within marriage can not only signify the level of closeness but also emphasise marital responsibility.

In Amundsen’s (2022) research, one interviewee believes that the more identifying characteristics are shown in a sexting picture, the higher level of intimacy is revealed, as this behaviour emphasises the trust level in the relationship. Because marriage is culturally associated with sexual privacy and a shared private life, revealing identifying features can be read as a stronger signal of trust between spouses, rather than simply a sexual gesture (Smart, 2007). This illustrates how intimacy in digital form is not only emotional but also symbolic, showing identifiable features like face or private background that transform sexting from a sexual gesture

to a relational one. Thus, sexting can be seen as an extension of affection and a form of relational maintenance to build trust (Hasinoff, 2012). This blurs the line between emotional and sexual intimacy, suggesting that digital communication is not secondary to physical touch but a new language through which couples express affection, trust and commitment.

However, examining these intimate practices through the intersection of gender and marital status reveals that marital sexting is structured by gendered expectations.

Hochschild (1983) introduced “emotion work”, which refers to the act of managing one's emotional state that results in a facial and body language that is perceptible to the public – creating responses of care and closeness in others. Research showed that women contribute more of this “emotion work”, and this imbalance can shape women's experiences in intimate relationships (Strazdins and Broom, 2004).

Importantly, this phenomenon does not emerge in isolation but is shaped by wider societal pressure. This can be seen as a compulsory responsibility that is similar to the gender stereotype in marriage: husbands are expected to go to work, and wives are associated with taking care of the children and cooking. In terms of sexting, men in relationships often use it as a means of sexual validation or control, reaffirming their desirability and masculinity (Albury, 2015). By contrast, women in marriage face tension between social ideals of being “good wives” and being sexually open to sexting demands. This emotional anticipation also extends to digital intimate relationships. This helps explain why, for many wives, sexting is a digital continuation of emotional work that has long been expected and normalised in domestic life, as women were taught to be emotionally supportive from a young age (Barbee et al., 1993). Thereby, women in marriage may initiate or respond to sexting not only as a

form of desire but as part of maintaining emotional harmony. This indicates that the same intimate action can carry entirely different emotional meanings depending on gender. Unmarried women, in comparison, may be unconstrained by the bonds of matrimony and familial roles and may invest less emotionally. Thus, they would derive greater pleasure from engaging in sexting and focus on their own experiences and feelings.

Rather than treating this emotional work only as an obligation, Amundsen (2022) also suggests utilising it as a form of leverage in mediated intimacy. This is because initiating sexting may allow one partner to set the timing, tone, and level of intimacy shared, which can shape negotiation within the relationship. Overall, compared to non-married couples, married couples may see sexting not simply as a way to improve intimacy, but as an obligation that wives are expected to do in the relationship as emotional support. This suggests that intimacy through sexting is different in marriage compared to other intimate relationships. It also highlights how power is unequally distributed in marriage in terms of intimacy and emotional work. Based on what is discussed here, the next section will further examine how these dynamics shape consent within marital sexting.

Permanent Consent in Marital Sexting

Consent has been defined differently across many disciplines, including law, psychology and sociology. The consent in marriage, especially about sexting, can be

understood as sexual consent, which is often described as a continuous decision and able to be negotiated at any time rather than a one-time answer (Muehlenhard et al., 2016). Some also believe that consent can be implicit, which depends on the surroundings and can be inferred from context (Willis and Jozkowski, 2019).

However, the lack of explicitness in such consent reveals deeply gendered power dynamics and entrenched historical marital expectations. Many assume that there is “permanent consent” in marriage whereby consent is presumed to be ongoing rather than explicitly negotiated (Kersti Yllö and M. Gabriela Torres, 2016, p.1). This blurs the boundary between voluntary participation and obligation. As sexting is a digital extension of sexual life, it becomes hard when consent is taken for granted – especially since sending such digital content does not require any permission. From an intersectional perspective, it indicates that sexually related behaviour in marriage is influenced by marital and social norms instead of individual autonomy. Thereby, consent in marital sexting cannot be fully understood without analysing the social and historical conditions that influence how consent is assumed, expressed, and negotiated. This lays the foundation for unequal experiences of consent, which are further shaped by gendered expectations within the relationship.

Moreover, the “permanent consent” makes non-consensual sexting appear less visible or less likely to be recognised as problematic. For example, in England and Wales, there was no such law related to marital rape until 1991 (BBC Bitesize, n.d.), which means that before this law, sexual activity between spouses was largely assumed to be consensual. As a result, even though when one side – often the wife – did not agree to sexual activity, it was unlikely to be expressed or respected (Russell, 1990), especially saying “no” might be perceived as disrupting relational

harmony. When this logic comes to digital, sexting may be treated as something that does not require explicit agreement. Although there is no specific law or regulation regarding sexting between spouses, having awareness of the definition of consent and its importance should be encouraged. This can both show respect between partners and reduce the chances of reproducing similar behaviour of coerced intimacy. In comparison, when a similar problem occurs in non-marital romantic relationships, it is more readily recognised by law. It may fall under sexual harassment or other forms of sexual offence depending on the level of pressure involved (Lee and Crofts, 2015). Thus, the same act of pressured sexting can be interpreted differently depending on whether it occurs within or outside marriage. Consequently, consent in marital sexting may show mutual agreement on the surface, but it is fundamentally shaped by the interaction of gendered power dynamics, marital institution norms and legal history. All these aspects redefine what consent means and how it is practised in digital intimate interactions.

Vulnerability and Double Standards in Marital Sexting

Building on the earlier discussions of intimacy and consent, vulnerability in marital sexting also merits critical examination. Vulnerability does not refer to individual weaknesses; instead, it is a condition shaped by power relations and institutional norms (Rogers et al., 2014). In the context of digital intimacy, it arises when power, responsibility and trust are unevenly distributed, making one group of people more exposed to potential risks than others. Within marriage, the consent section has

highlighted how ambiguous consent can cause unsatisfying relational experiences and even legal consequences. This ambiguity can be understood as a form of vulnerability, as it places the wives in a disadvantaged position where their refusals are less visible. From this perspective, vulnerability in marital sexting is not limited to explicit violation but is embedded in the everyday dynamics of expectation and unequal responsibility.

In addition, the leakage of marital sexting can lead to vulnerability due to public judgment and external criticism, which further exposes gendered double standards between wives and husbands. Such leakage may occur through various channels, including hacking or revenge porn perpetrated by one spouse – the behaviours that can be used to threaten the other, such as coercing compliance with marital demands or deterring divorce (Maddocks, 2018). While a detailed analysis of the reasons behind the leakage will not be further examined here, their potential risks serve to highlight the gendered disparities in how harm is experienced when private digital sexual content is disclosed. Marriage is widely perceived to carry strong expectations of privacy and shared responsibility, particularly in relation to sexual intimacy. Some research argues that married couples believe sexual content should only be kept between them and not be disclosed to outsiders (Jamieson, 1998; Smart, 2007). Therefore, when intimate content such as sexting becomes visible beyond the relationship, whether intentional or unintentional, it is more likely to be considered a betrayal of marital trust rather than a neutral digital incident. In this scenario, women may face “slut-shaming” – a form of gendered moral judgement that criticises women for their sexual expression by labelling them as unchaste (Skeggs, 1997). Within marriage, this judgment can be intensified. This is because

the exposure is not simply personal embarrassment but the failure to keep marital privacy and responsibility. Compared to non-marital relationships, marriage involves higher expectations of privacy and commitment, which determines how vulnerability is shaped. This is because non-marital relationships have more flexible boundaries around intimacy and disclosure, with fewer moral obligations to keep a shared private life internally at all costs (Roseneil and Budgeon, 2004). This demonstrates how vulnerability for women is exacerbated through cultural expectations surrounding marriage and respectability. Men, by contrast, are less likely to be subjected to the same level of sexual shaming in the same situation. Research suggests that male sexuality is often normalised or trivialised, resulting in less reputational damage when facing exposure (Salter, 2016). However, this does not mean that men are unaffected by such incidents. Some also indicate that men experience anxiety and fear of humiliation, but dominant norms of masculinity discourage men from openly acknowledging vulnerability or positioning themselves as victims (Kimmel, Hearn and Connell, 2005). Consequently, male vulnerability in marital sexting is not absent, but systematically minimised or even ignored, reinforcing gendered hierarchies in how harm is addressed. Together, these patterns reveal that vulnerability in marital sexting operates through gendered double standards rather than equal exposure to harm. This uneven distribution of vulnerability highlights how marriage, gender norms, and digital intimacy intersect to shape who bears the social and emotional cost when private sexual communication becomes visible.

Furthermore, the impact of marital sexting leakage can be intensified by religious and cultural beliefs. Taking Muslim communities as an example, many follow an

extended family structure where three or more generations live together and support each other, where one family member's behaviour, especially female, can reflect the reputation of the wider family, including parents and extended relatives (Dhami, 2000; Mishra and Basu, 2014). Mishra and Basu (2014) found that many Muslim women have brought this sense of collective responsibility into digital spaces. For instance, when they post online, they still obey the family rules and put effort into preserving family honour through actively managing their self-presentation. In such contexts, if marital sexting content circulates beyond a Muslim marriage, the consequences may extend far beyond the couple themselves and turn into shame directed at the entire extended family. This is because sexual behaviour, even within marriage, is closely monitored under moral and religious norms that emphasise privacy (Alli, 2011). As a result, women may face judgment from both the wider community and disappointment from family members who perceive it as bringing shame to the household, which can place women in a position of double pressure. These differences show how vulnerability in marital sexting is shaped by overlapping expectations about gender, marriage and religion, making some women far more exposed to harm when sexual privacy is broken.

Social and Political Concerns: Gendered Shame and Legal Ambiguity

The previous sections have demonstrated how sexting within marriage is formed by gendered power relations, which are shaped by multiple structures, including social

norms, marital status and religious beliefs. Building on this analysis, this section considers two key concerns that emerge at the social and political level.

First, the different reaction that society gives to men and women in sexting leakage reveals the social concern rooted in gender expectations. Ahmed (2014, p.107) defined shame as a social feeling “experienced as the affective cost of not following the scripts of normative existence”. Thus, individuals only feel shame not because they fail in achievement but because of society’s expectations of them. The reason behind slut-shaming directed at women in marital sexting was socially structured. From an early age, women and men were taught in different ways with different expectations regarding modesty and responsibility. In terms of sexuality education, women were expected to have self-respect and not to be the ones to initiate sex. While men’s sexual expression is afforded greater tolerance or framed as less consequential (Grose, Grabe and Kohfeldt, 2014). As a result, shame is more readily attached to women, becoming a disciplinary tool that pressures them to conform to socially approved forms of intimacy, particularly within marriage. This dynamic leaves the structural inequalities of gender and marriage unsolved, also amplifying women’s vulnerability in marital sexting.

Second, at the political level, the dominance of shame as a response also reflects the limits of legal recognition. Although the law has become more aware of physical and sexual violence within marriage, it is still less able to deal with the pressure and harm caused by digital and emotional means. Consequently, the prevailing dynamics of coercion in the context of marital sexting remain under-acknowledged and unchallenged. The absence of clear institutional responses enables such harm to be

treated as a private issue, reinforcing silence and leaving shame to function as a substitute for accountability.

Conclusion

By examining intimacy, consent and vulnerability, this essay highlighted that sexting within heterosexual marriage is not neutral, but is shaped by cultural, social and marital institutions. Sexting as a form of digital intimacy is not merely a medium through which spouses can establish a connection to show affection to each other. Instead, the analysis has demonstrated that wives often take more responsibility for emotional work in marriage, including sexting, as a result of gendered expectations embedded within both society and marital norms. These gendered expectations also influence how consent is understood within married couples. The assumption of “permanent consent” has historically been presumed within marital relationships, even before explicit legal recognition challenged this belief. However, as this essay has argued, intimate practices, including sexting, require ongoing mutual consent and an understanding of each other’s boundaries that are not automatically guaranteed by marital status. At the same time, these assumptions produce uneven forms of vulnerability towards different genders. For instance, wives are subjected to slut-shaming and sexual double standards when marital sexting is exposed to the public, as well as experiencing more social consequences compared to husbands.

Overall, marital sexting cannot be understood as a neutral consensual form of digital

intimacy, but as a practice that reproduces gendered power relations through everyday assumptions about intimacy, consent and vulnerability within marriage. In turn, this serves as a poignant reminder that even in the digital age, the fundamental elements of marriage – trust, respect, and genuine mutual understanding – continue to hold greater significance than any other aspect.